

UNIFORMS AND EQUIPMENT

During World War II, military uniforms went through a transitional phase as old gave way to new. Traditional uniforms – such as those worn by the Japanese infantryman – distinguished the soldier from both the enemy and civilians, and provided him with a sense of solidarity with his fellow troops. The new functional uniforms, however, typically worn by specialists such as fliers and armoured troops, were designed with practical considerations in mind. This approach to uniform would become increasingly common in the post-war era.



▲ IMPERIAL JAPANESE ARMY UNIFORM

Date 1930

Origin Japan

Material Cotton (wool in winter)

This infantryman's uniform was worn during the early stages of World War II. It consisted of a peaked cap and the single-breasted M90 tunic, which had a stand-and-fall collar.

Leather peak

Rank insignia



▲ PANZER JACKET

Date 1930s

Origin Germany

Material Wool

Panzer crews were issued with black, hip-length, double-breasted jackets. The colour helped to conceal oil and grease stains.

Cuff title of SS-Leibstandarte Adolf Hitler division, Hitler's personal bodyguard

Helmet pressed from single steel sheet

► BRODIE HELMET

Date 1939

Origin UK

Material Steel

Designed by the British inventor John Brodie, this was the standard steel helmet worn by British troops during both world wars. Based on the shape of a medieval kettle hat, the helmet gave protection from shrapnel and shell splinters.



P40 "austerity version" without pleated pockets and front fly

► BATTLEDRESS JACKET

Date 1942

Origin UK

Material Wool

Battledress was a new uniform adopted by the British Army from 1939 onwards. It included trousers and a short jacket (or blouse). This simpler P40 battledress jacket utilized less fabric and was introduced in 1942.



Formation insignia